Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Marianne Moore's "The Intra-mural Rat"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

apostrophe,
comparison,
conceit,
connection,
imagery,
rhyme, and
wit.

The contestant should recognize the commonality characterizing much of Marianne Moore's poetry, especially the selections that we are reading. Moore makes unexpected connections between, fairly frequently, the natural world and something else, in this case a rat and "many men." The tie-breaking essays might simply address this comparison, though some attention should be paid to the "interesting" aspect(s) of comparing men the persona has known to a rat scurrying through a wall.

The young writer might suggest that the comparison of rat and man (the unexpected jump) is not so extraordinary; however, the intent of the persona's comparison of "many men" to a rat between the walls is to note that her own awareness of them (both the rat and the men) is short lived—either they are beyond her immediate interest, or they are not around long enough to be a real bother.

The thrust of the persona's observation of her (?) own reaction is to minimize the many men's importance: as is a rat's presence between the walls of a house a distraction, so too the presence of these many men within the walls of her life.

The strength of the comparison, what might be considered the conceit, is the likening of the walls within which a rat might scurry to the framing suggested by the two halves of a parenthesis (within which she notes the men hastening), the conceit itself representative of her wit (with which she denigrates the men she has met).